

PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

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August 26, 2026

Wherefore “data”?

Linguistics:

- “Data” in common usage: *mass noun* (like “rice,” “rain,” “music,” etc.) → singular
- “Data” in scientific usage: plural of *datum* → plural

Usage:

- If: “data” ≡ “information”: *singular*
- If:
 - “data” ≡ “facts”: *plural*
 - “data” ≡ “data points”: *plural*

What is “data”?

“*Data*: A reinterpretable representation of information in a formalized manner suitable for communication, interpretation, or processing.”

- Borgman (2008)

Data isn't *only* information

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“Data”:

- ...requires *context*
- ...requires *purpose*
- ...implies / actualizes *values*

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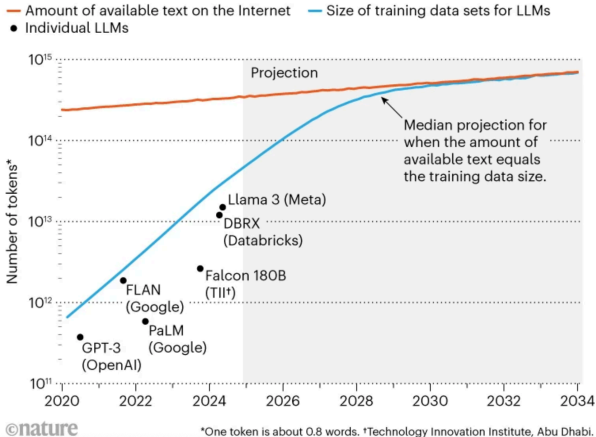
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2. "As we collect more data, we prioritize things that fit patterns of collection."
3. "Data sets outlive the rationale for their collection."
4. "Especially combined, data sets reveal far more than intended."
5. "Data collection is a transaction that is the result of an invisible relationship."

Jones (2024): “AI is running out of data...”

RUNNING OUT OF DATA

The amount of text data used to train large language models (LLMs) is rapidly approaching a crisis point. An estimate suggests that, by 2028, developers will be using data sets that match the amount of text that is available on the Internet.



For Friday (August 28)...

Bring a laptop computer.

Alternatives:

- Bring your own...
- Borrow one:
 - Place: Common Services, W107 Pattee Library, 96 Curtin Road
 - Terms: Seven days, \$25/day overdue charges
 - Contact: ul-common-services@psu.edu